The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Mark Carney, Canada's prime minister, said he had a "positive conversation" with **Donald Trump** after America's president threatened to block the opening of the Gordie Howe International Bridge linking Ontario and Michigan. Mr Trump accuses Canada of trying to "take advantage" of America. Mr Carney pointed out that Canada paid for the construction of the bridge, which used American steel. America also has joint ownership.

A gunman killed at least nine people at a school and a related residence in the Canadian province of **British Columbia**, before reportedly turning the weapon on himself. Authorities said that 25 other people were injured during the attack in Tumbler Ridge. A motive has yet to be confirmed.

The president of **Samsung Electronics**' chip division, Jaihyuk Song, said the firm had got its mojo back thanks to its HBM4 technology. South Korea's most valuable company is expected to begin production of the new generation of high-bandwidth memory chips this month. It has been struggling to compete with SK Hynix, a local rival.

During a congressional hearing **Howard Lutnick** admitted that he visited **Jeffrey Epstein's** island with his family in 2012.

Documents released by the Department of Justice revealed America's commerce secretary had closer ties to the dead sex offender than previously thought. Meanwhile an uncovered FBI interview revealed **Mr Trump** told a police chief in 2006 that "everyone" knew about Epstein's crimes.

Retail sales in America were unexpectedly flat in December, compared with the previous month. Spending on clothing, furniture and cars fell after an initial flurry of holiday shopping. The disappointing figures, which are not adjusted for inflation, might reflect consumers' anxiety over rising costs and the impact of Mr Trump's tariffs. Extreme winter weather might have chilled January sales, too.

Paramount, a film and TV giant, sweetened its offer for **Warner Bros Discovery.** The firm is trying to derail a competing acquisition attempt by Netflix, which values Warner at $83bn. Paramount agreed to pay the $2.8bn fee that Warner would have to pay Netflix to terminate its bid, plus $1.5bn in fees related to Warner's debt refinancing.

The Supreme Court of the **Philippines** ruled that same-sex couples could co-own property. The decision grants property rights under the country's Family Code law—typically reserved for wedded partners. Same-sex unions are prohibited in the deeply conservative country. The Philippines is also the only country, apart from the Vatican, where divorce is illegal.

Figure of the day: 90%, the share of informal jobs in India. Read the full story.

Photograph: Alamy

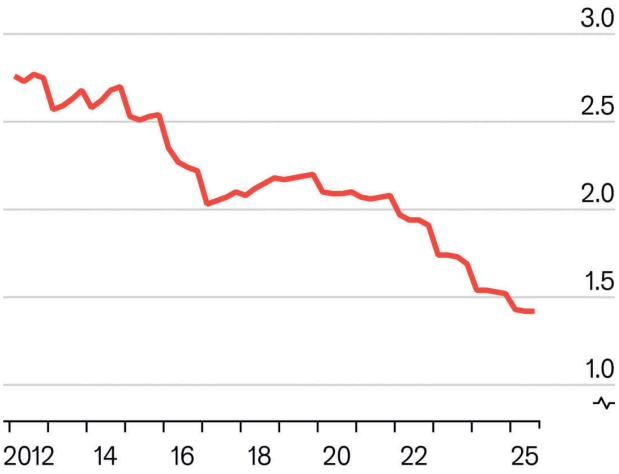
China’s reluctance to cut interest rates

Next month China’s government will reveal its inflation target for this year (probably 2%). It will almost certainly undershoot it, as it did last year. Figures released on Wednesday showed that consumer prices rose by only 0.2% in January, compared with a year earlier, despite a 77% rise in the cost of gold jewellery. The inflation rate for 2025 as a whole was zero.

Weak inflation is a sign that the economy is underperforming. Why is China’s central bank not cutting interest rates in response? It did last month lower the cost of lending for specific purposes, such as health care, farming and the energy transition. But it fears that easing monetary policy more broadly would further squeeze the profits of China’s banks, which now enjoy very little “margin” between their borrowing costs and their lending rates. To keep the banks cosy, it is willing to keep the economy cool.

Margin fall

China, commercial banks, net interest margin, %



Source: Wind

Photograph: Reuters

Decoding the Donroe doctrine

The western hemisphere's military chiefs will gather on Wednesday in a hotel in Washington, DC to hear what America's new interpretation of the Monroe Doctrine has in store. Attendees include officers from nearly all countries in Latin America and the Caribbean. Countries that rule over territories in the region—such as Britain, Denmark, France and the Netherlands—will be represented, too. Excluded are Venezuela, whose leader was snatched by American forces last month; and Cuba, whose regime America is keen to topple next.

American combatant commanders regularly host big meetings of senior officers in the regions where they operate. What is unusual is for America's chairman of the joint chiefs of staff, now General Dan Caine, to summon foreign military chiefs to Washington.

Expect emollient words about "strong partnerships" and exhortations to fight narco gangs. But the message will be uncompromising: America dominates the region; squeeze foes; push out the likes of China and Russia.

Photograph: Getty Images

A hollow anniversary in Iran

Revolution Day is usually marked by state parades and ideological bombast across Iran. On Wednesday Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the supreme leader, will again be lauding the “glory” of the Islamic republic forged in 1979. But this year feels different. A month after the regime’s bloody suppression of protests, Iran remains in mourning. Just over a month ago, on January 8th, Mr Khamenei unleashed his snipers who killed thousands countrywide. That bloodshed is more prominent in the public memory than the revolution 47 years ago.

Tens of thousands have been jailed, including former officials advocating reform. According to regime opponents, the rate of executions is climbing. The currency is collapsing, deepening Iranians’ economic woes. The presence offshore of Donald Trump’s armada raises fears of war, even as Iranian negotiators are in Oman hoping to promote a negotiated settlement with America. Mr Khamenei now speaks by pre-recorded video, wary of assassination. While he focuses on the past revolution, most Iranians are fixed on the transition to come.

Photograph: Reuters

Bibi’s nerve-racking trip to Washington

What happens next in Iran will be largely down to America. Israel’s prime minister, Binyamin Netanyahu, will meet President Donald Trump on Wednesday to discuss his administration’s intentions towards the country. Mr Netanyahu worries about two possible outcomes: a limited nuclear deal and limited military action. The first might contain Iran’s nuclear programme without reducing its arsenal of ballistic missiles or constraining the regional militias that it controls. The second might provoke regional chaos, and missile strikes on Israel, without bringing down Iran’s clerical regime.

It’s the toppling of the theocracy that Mr Netanyahu probably wants. But Mr Trump wants to avoid the protracted conflict that might be needed to bring it about. That may explain his recent change of tack. Last month he urged Iranians to keep protesting, even as the regime was killing them, because “help is on its way”. He sent the *USS Abraham Lincoln*, an aircraft-carrier, to underscore the promise. On Friday, though, he hailed “very good talks” with Iran in Oman. That set alarm bells ringing in Jerusalem.

Photograph: AP

American jobs: tardy but tenacious

Thankfully, America's second data delay didn't last long. A brief partial government shutdown held up several releases of labour statistics, including the closely watched non-farm jobs numbers for January. (Late last year these had been in limbo for over a month, when the government shut down for 43 days.) The new figures are expected on Wednesday, five days late. Forecasters expect them to be solid, but not stonking: 70,000 new jobs, a bit better than the 50,000 in December.

America's labour market looked a little wobbly in the second half of 2025, but seems to have stabilised. The unemployment rate is 4.4%, not much higher than last summer, and jobless claims have dipped to near post-pandemic lows. That makes Donald Trump's crusade for interest-rate cuts from the Federal Reserve harder to justify. Lower rates might make sense as medicine for an ailing labour market, but not for an economy in fine fettle.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Cymru is the alternative name for which nation, part of the UK?

Tuesday: Which American prison was home to both Al Capone and Machine Gun Kelly?

The task of leadership is not to put greatness into humanity, but to elicit it, for the greatness is already there.

John Buchan